



Flag Up, Knock Anyway

Walk-Up Interruptions Before and After a Desk-Level Do-Not-Disturb Flag

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The problem

A small flip-flag raised beside a monitor is meant to hold off a walk-up question. Does it change whether colleagues interrupt, or only how they announce that they’re about to?

Research questions

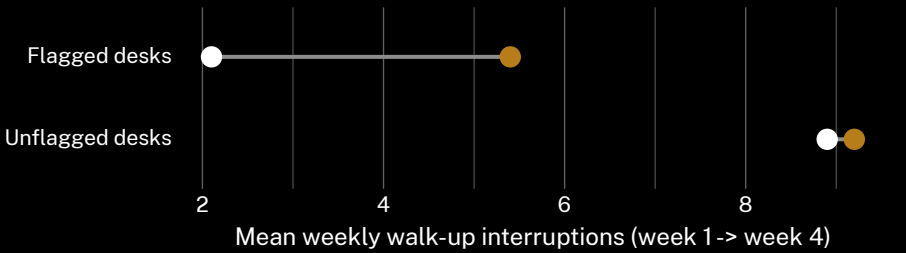
- Do flagged desks receive fewer walk-up interruptions than unflagged desks over a four-week deployment?
- Does any early gap persist, narrow, or close as desk tenure with the flag lengthens?
- What changes at the moment of interruption — the approach, the opener, the apology — when the flag is up?

Study design

- n = 46 desks · 6 open-plan floors · 23 flag-issued, 23 matched unflagged controls · 4-week deployment
- self-logged walk-up diary cross-checked against 15-minute observer spot-checks on two floors
- flag colour, desk tenure, and floor held constant across arms; no flag-raising protocol beyond “raise it when you mean it”

Findings

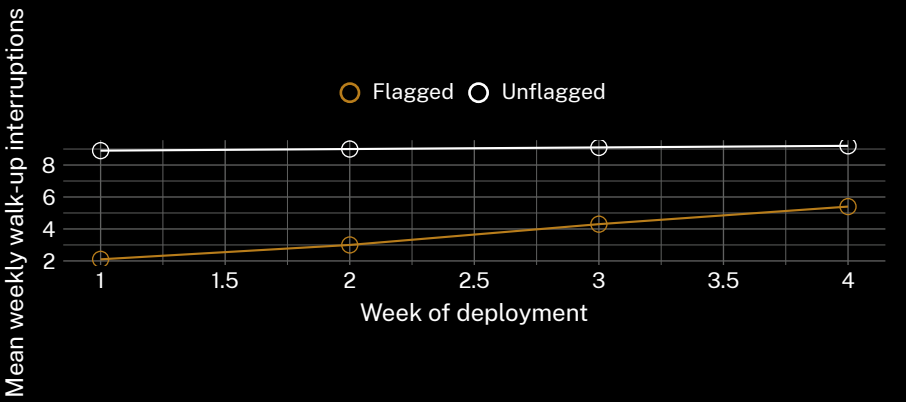
Flagged desks log markedly fewer interruptions in week 1. By week 4 the count has risen to within a fifth of the unflagged baseline, while the share of interruptions opening with an apology moves the other way.



Mean weekly walk-up interruptions at flagged desks rose from 2.1 to 5.4 between week 1 and week 4 (n = 23 desks), closing 71% of the initial gap to unflagged desks, which held at 8.9–9.2 throughout.

Implications

The flag buys a genuine first week, then decays as colleagues learn which raised flags they can talk past. What replaces avoidance is not restraint but etiquette: 64% of week-4 flagged-desk interruptions open with “sorry, quick one”, against 19% at unflagged desks in the same week — the flag has stopped gating the approach and started scripting it. The unflagged baseline itself barely moves, which is its own small finding: without a flag to talk past, colleagues weren’t holding back much to begin with. Next: test whether a flag that expires after a fixed interval holds its early effect for longer than one raised indefinitely, and whether resetting it weekly resets the etiquette along with the count.



Flagged-desk interruptions climbed in every week of the deployment (2.1, 3.0, 4.3, 5.4); the unflagged baseline was flat across the same four weeks (8.9, 9.0, 9.1, 9.2).

References

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2. Mark, G., Gudith, D., & Klocke, U. (2008). The cost of interrupted work: More speed and stress. *Proceedings of CHI 2008*, 107–110. doi:10.1145/1357054.1357072
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4. Smith-Jackson, T. L., & Klein, K. W. (2009). Open-plan offices: Task performance and mental workload. *Journal of Environmental Psychology*, 29(2), 279–289. doi:10.1016/j.jenvp.2008.09.002

Self-logged diary data only; no desk audio or video retained beyond the weekly coding pass.

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